# Dvar Torah – Haazinu

## The Final Full Parsha

With *Haazinu*, we arrive at the last full parsha of the Torah. *V'Zot HaBerachah* is still to come, but that is read on *Simchat Torah* and not in the regular aliyot cycle. In terms of our weekly Torah journey, *Haazinu* is the closing chapter.

It opens with the call: *"Haazinu ha-shamayim va'adabeirah, v'tishma ha'aretz imrei fi"* — "Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak; let the earth hear the words of my mouth" (Devarim 32:1). The very name of the parsha is about listening.

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## The Power of Listening

Listening has been central throughout the Torah. At Har Sinai, Am Yisrael declared *na'aseh v'nishma* — "we will do and we will listen" (Shemot 24:7). They did not say *na'aseh v'nireh* (we will see), or *na'aseh v'nistakel* (we will investigate). The essence of faith is not in seeing or analyzing, but in listening.

The mitzvah of *shofar* too is about hearing: *"yom teruah yihyeh lachem"* (Bamidbar 29:1). Just last night, as Yom Kippur ended, we again heard the blast of the shofar — a sound that pierces the heart, awakens the soul, and calls us to renewal.

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## Moshe's Final Song

Moshe Rabbeinu's farewell is not given as a lecture, but as a *shirah* — a poem, a song. It is both a hymn of praise for Hashem's blessings and a sharp rebuke against *avodah zarah*.

And significantly, it is read in the week between Yom Kippur and Sukkot. At the very height of holiness, we are reminded of how easy it is to slip back into distraction, to forget our purpose. After Yom Kippur, life resumes — building sukkot, preparing for Shabbat, returning to work. The noise of "what do I want, what do I have, how can I get more?" can drown out the voice of Hashem.

This is the deeper danger of *avodah zarah*. In Moshe's time, it meant worshipping foreign gods, bowing to idols of wood and stone. But the root of idolatry is misdirected devotion — giving ourselves over to something unworthy of that worship. Today, *avodah zarah* can be the endless

pursuit of personal wants, desires, and gratification. When our lives revolve around self-interest — money, status, power, or even comfort — we are no less guilty of placing an “idol” between ourselves and Hashem.

That is why the Torah keeps circling back to this sin. Not because we are tempted to set up statues, but because we are always tempted to put ourselves at the center. Moshe’s final song calls us to listen — to step back, hear Hashem’s voice, and re-align our desires with His will.

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## A Contemporary Wake-Up Call

This year, the reminder was tragically close. On Yom Kippur, we heard the news of murders in England. In my own family, it struck directly — my wife’s sister-in-law’s father-in-law was meant to be on guard duty at that shul. Had he been there, he would have been among the victims.

Rashi comments (Devarim 32:26) that Hashem reveals in advance the punishments to come, so that enemies cannot think they have true power over us. Philosophically, this connects to *bechirah chofshit*, free will. Hashem decrees outcomes in the world, but individuals choose whether to become the ones who carry them out. Even our enemies, in their cruelty, are still agents within Hashem’s greater plan.

The message for us is clear: these events are wake-up calls. They remind us that there is teshuvah still to do, responsibility still to take.

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## Responsibility and Endurance

This has been Moshe’s theme throughout Sefer Devarim: responsibility. Responsibility of the individual for himself, and responsibility for one another — *kol Yisrael areivim zeh bazeh* (Shevuot 39a). We are guarantors for each other.

Yes, we fail. That is why tragedies shake us awake, why the *tochachot* appear in the Torah. Not to break us, but to remind us that we are meant to rise again.

Before Rosh Hashanah, I heard mekubalim warn that this year would be difficult for Am Yisrael. But they also emphasized: it is in our hands. We can make it right.

And this is what Moshe longed for — that Am Yisrael would endure. Thousands of years later, here we stand, living proof of Hashem’s promise: *“Ki lo yitosh Hashem amo”* — Hashem will never abandon His people (Tehillim 94:14).

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## From Warning to Embrace

Sometimes we are the head, sometimes the tail (Devarim 28:13–44). Sometimes we rise, sometimes we stumble. But Hashem's love never wavers. That is why *Haazinu* is read right before Sukkot — the festival of being enveloped in that love.

In the sukkah we are surrounded by the *ananei hakavod*, just as our ancestors were in the desert. We remember the clothing that never wore out, the fire that guided us, the food that sustained us. And then Shemini Atzeret comes — that "extra day," as Rashi explains (Vayikra 23:36), because Hashem does not want to let us go. These are all expressions of Hashem's love and wanting to be close to us. We are rebuked to be brought close so we can be properly aligned to feel Hashem's love and not just stuck in our own small works..

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## Closing Message

*Haazinu* is filled with stern rebukes, but beneath them lies a song of love. Moshe warns us again about *avodah zarah* — not only the idols of the past, but the idols of the self: chasing desires, wealth, or comfort at the expense of our covenant with Hashem.

And yet, all the warnings are spoken out of love. Hashem wants us. Hashem wants us to want Him.

That is why Moshe ends with the call: *Haazinu* — listen. Because when we open our ears, we can hear not only the Torah and the shofar, but also the song of creation itself, calling us back to Hashem.

**Shabbat Shalom. Shanah Tovah. G'mar Chatimah Tovah.**